



Wyze cam V3

The latest security camera is IP65 rated and also features new sensors that enables colour night vision. <http://digit.in/nov20-57>



TCL announces 5G handset

The TCL 10 5G comes with a Snapdragon 765G SoC and a 4500mAh battery that supports reverse charging. <http://digit.in/nov20-58>

Mi Smart Speaker

A great purchase for first-time smart speaker buyers

Xiaomi launched the Mi Smart Speaker in India to take on the likes of Google Nest Mini and Amazon Echo Dot 3rd Gen. What makes it interesting is its competitive price. The speaker is priced at ₹3,999, while early buyers can grab it as low as ₹3,499. Let's see how this affordable smart speaker fares in our review.

Design and build

The Mi Smart Speaker measures 131x104 x151mm and weighs 853g. These dimensions make it a lot bigger than the doughnut sized Google Home Mini and Amazon Echo Dot. The overall size of the speaker is four to five times that of a Google Home Mini.

In terms of design, it's constructed with a combination of metal mesh wrapped in the centre and the frame is made of ABS material with a warm matte finish. On the top, it has touch-based buttons bordered by a ring of aurora light band on the corners. Sadly the buttons aren't backlit, which will make it difficult to spot in the dark. The aurora light uses 24 LED light beads underneath to produce different colour gradients to add to its visual aesthetics. The two microphones are also placed on the top of the speaker.

The bottom ditch sharp edges and has curved corners instead, along with four rubber tips to give it a firm hold on most surfaces. There are no ports on the body except for one that facilitates the power chord.

Set up and smart home features

The Mi Smart Speaker is straightforward to set up. You just have to plug the speaker to power it up, install and go to the 'Google Home' app on your phone, and it will automatically detect the speaker when it's in proximity.

Like any Google Assistant-based smart speaker, this one also lets you do



basic tasks like setting reminders, booking an Uber, controlling IoT-based appliances and so on. The speaker also has Chromecast built-in, which worked just as intended when we tried to stream videos and music on a smart TV. It can also be used as a standalone Bluetooth speaker in case you lose Wi-Fi.

Microphone and voice response

While microphones and voice response are the spine of any smart speaker, it is one of the areas where the Mi Smart Speaker falls short. Xiaomi has used two far-field microphones on this one, placed right on the top to avoid any blockage. However, we found it to be inconsistent at a higher volume.

It would be unfair to be overly critical about the voice response as it does a pretty good job at up to 70 percent volume, but we also can't deny it requires you to yell at it more than once when you pump up the volume to higher levels.

Sound quality

The smart speaker has a 2.5-inch, 12W full-range driver with a paper dia-

phragm, which makes it far superior to the Google Home Mini or Echo Dot 3rd Gen, on paper. The voice coil and U-shaped air duct design at the bottom of the loudspeaker make room for more bass, which is also something that its competitors lack. It also comes with 'DTS professional tuning'.

Expectedly, its sound output is much superior to its competitors. The Bass is prominent enough to be felt, but not something which can make your windows vibrate. The quality of the sound, however, isn't as moving, although you can tune it as per your requirement using the EQ option in the Google App. It has a soft sound signature, which is good for music playback but not as much for voice. The DTS tuning seems to fail in eliminating unnecessary bass from podcasts or news. The bass, at times, overpowers



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the mids and lows as well. Still, it's undeniably a no-brainer to pick this instead of its smaller competitors at this price.

In order to get stereo playback, you can pair up to two Mi Smart Speakers to get a more immersive audio output.

Bottomline

The Mi Smart Speaker is a dream come true for first-time smart speaker buyers. It blows the Amazon Echo Dot 3rd Gen and Google Nest Mini out of the bush in terms of audio quality and loudness. It does everything a Google Assistant-based smart speaker can do, so the only downside is its inconsistent mic response, which can be overlooked, given its low-price.

—Sudhanshu Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

SPEAKER: 12W speaker with DTS Professional Tuned Sound | **OS COMPATIBILITY:** Android 4.4 and above, iOS 9.0 and above | **TOUCHPAD:** Yes | **MUSIC STREAMING:** Gaana, Saavn, Google Play Music, YouTube Music | **OUTPUT TO STEREO SYSTEM:** Built-in Chromecast | **VOICE ASSISTANT:** Google Voice Assistant | **NETWORK CONNECTIVITY:** IEEE 802.11a/b/g/n/ac (2.4 GHz/5 GHz) Wi-Fi, Bluetooth 4.2 | **WEIGHT:** 853 g

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